Transactional Reader Response Theory

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Introduction

The transactional reader response theory is a theory that explains the transaction between the reader and the text when reading a text. There are multiple ways that the transactional reader response theory can take place in the classroom. This theory, primarily associated with Louisa Rosenblatt, is all about the transaction between the reader and the text and these two parties contribute to make meaning of the text. The reader will connect the text with past experiences and knowledge to interpret and determine the potential meaning of it. When students make a connection to the text, they are able to make a deeper connection with the text which can lead to productive dialogue in discussion and a better personalized understanding of the text. When students understand the text better, teachers are able to link their class's understanding of the text to content which increases their chances of understanding the content. The transactional reader response theory also encourages students to have diverse perspectives and meanings of different texts. There are multiple strategies for teachers to use transactional reader response theory to help students better understand the meaning of texts and content.

Overview of Theory

The transactional reader response theory first emerged in the 1930s and gained popularity as time progressed. It gained popularity due to the recognition of varied interpretations that readers have on literary works (Ariz & Kunjanman, 2021, p.253). This theory emphasizes that no reader is identical and is the key to the process of interpretation. Louisa Rosenblatt has been essential in the development of this theory and according to her, a transaction is an event that happens between the reader and the text at that particular moment. The meaning depends on the moment of transaction which means that the reader is bringing meaning to a text to get meaning from it (Marhaeni, 2016, p. 207). This theory is reader centered so instead of the text already

having meaning that the author has given for the reader to grasp, this theory argues that the text aids the reader in building their interpretation of the text.

Strategies For the Classroom

There are multiple ways for teachers to integrate transactional reader response theory into reading and writing instruction. Reading facilitates writing, the connection that students make to reading could be demonstrated in another one of the six language arts. Reading and writing are two mutually reinforcing processes so the author has the power to create meaning through language. Readers can use their own experiences and knowledge to interpret meaning from text, while writers can create meaning through text (Marhaeni, 2016, p. 212). Some of the recommended strategies from Davis (1992), to evoke readers' response in the classroom is to make the classroom reader centered. By putting a spotlight on students' responses, teachers can show their students that their responses are honored and valued as a reader. One of the ways to make your classroom reader centered is reader response journals. Some students may use journals to make connections, some students may use the journals to ask questions, and they may even use questioning to form their response. Sharing responses and class discussions is another strategy to implement into your classroom to evoke readers' responses. When students share their ideas, students are exposed to diverse perspectives and able to share their own response with others. When deciding what activities to do for lesson plans and for reading instruction, it's important to determine what purpose it is supposed to serve. Ariz & Kunjanman (2021) split literature instruction into three different models, the language model, the personal growth model, and the cultural model. The language model is for the purpose to deconstruct texts and to serve specific linguistic goals. The personal growth model is to serve the personal development of the reader. The cultural model serves the purpose of readers to understand universal ideas and

thoughts. Teachers can provide the environment to give readers the opportunity to directly respond to texts, like discussions and journal entries or pick texts with purpose for students to make connections with, to make their classroom reader centered.

Effects on Student Learning and Teaching Practice

The effects of a reader centered classroom that integrates transactional reader response theory can be seen through the students and instruction. Students are valued and encouraged to express their perspectives and make connections with content (Ariz & Kunjanman, 2021, p.253). An important component of making a reader centered classroom and integrating transactional reader response theory is the teacher. The teacher should provide a productive environment for students to carry out reading and writing activities. Reading instruction aims at producing independent, successful readers but all readers read differently in different contexts depending on their purpose of reading, difficulty of the text, prior knowledge, interests, and motivation to understand the text. The teacher should create an environment where students feel a sense of security to express their perspectives and they have time and opportunity to reflect on them (Marhaeni, 2016, p. 215). The effects you will start to see in students is that they will become more engaged in their own reading, discussions will let students feel a sense of togetherness and ownership, students will have an increase of individualization and critical thinking, and build respect for differences in ideas.

Multicultural Texts

Introducing texts that students can make connections to are vital in reading instruction but also presents an opportunity to integrate multicultural texts. Exposing students to universal thoughts and ideologies gives them the opportunities to immerse in different cultures in comparison to their own. There is great importance in relating text to culture because the teacher

has the option to present a text in hopes that students will make a connection with ease. When the teacher includes opportunities for student opinions to be expressed, students will be able to show their difference in opinions and build respect for their differences. Reading has a social function so students are able to gain knowledge as well as exchange ideas with peers and texts.

Conclusion

The transactional reading theory can be integrated in the classroom and reading instruction. A reader centered classroom focuses on putting a spotlight on student voices and the meaning they take away from the text. The transactional reader response theory is a transaction that happens between reader and text so it’s important for teachers to methodically choose texts that students can make a connection with which in turn will help students gain a better understanding of the text and the content. The teacher must facilitate the students' needs and interests so the students are able to reap the benefits of reading which is improvements in language skills and knowledge.

References

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